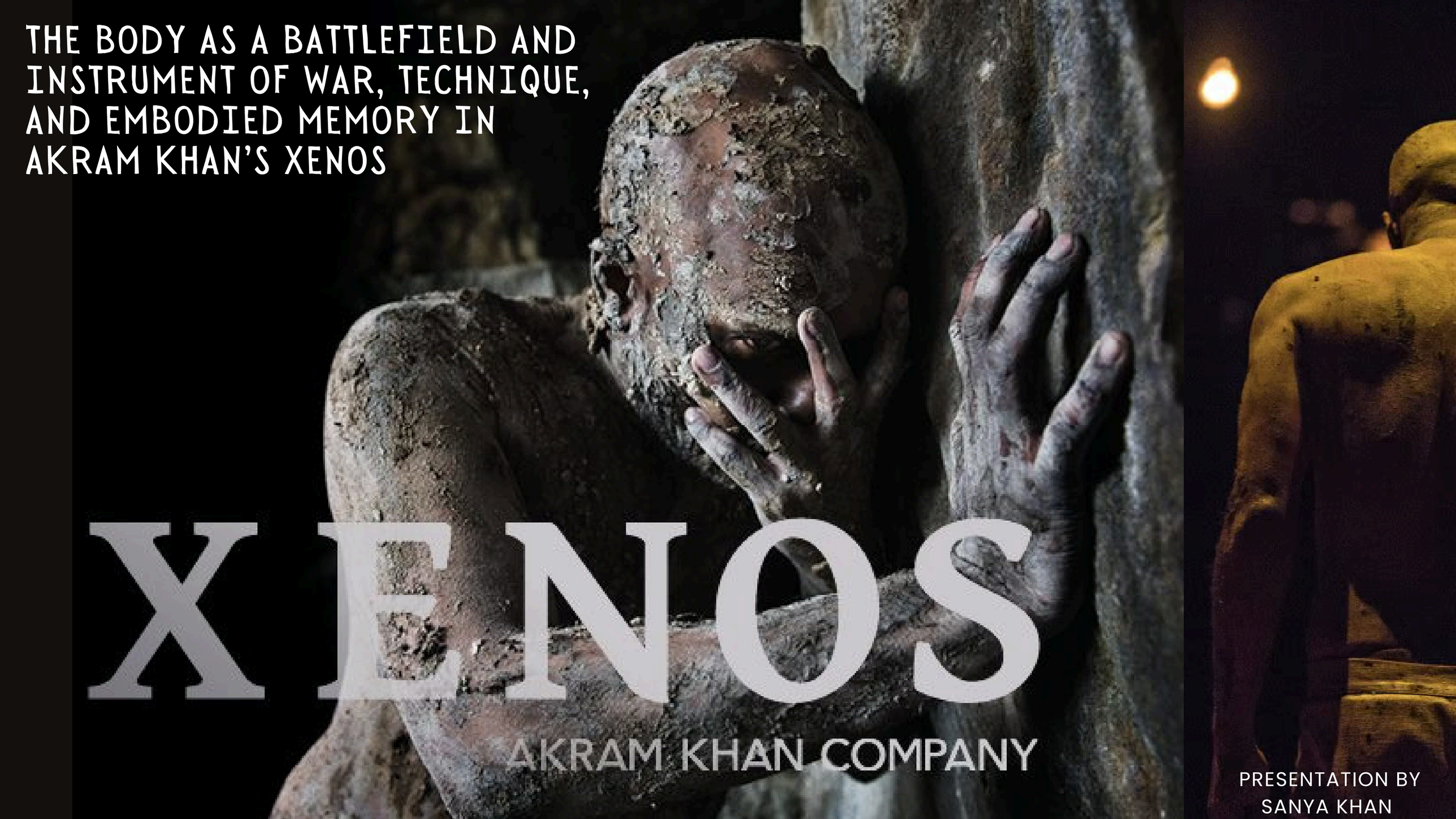
THE BODY AS A BATTLEFIELD AND INSTRUMENT OF WAR, TECHNIQUE, AND EMBODIED MEMORY IN AKRAM KHAN'S XENOS



PRESENTATION BY
SANYA KHAN

A CHOREOGRAPHIC ANALYSIS

How Xenos uses classical kathak training with influences of contemporary dance to stage an Indian colonial soldier whose body becomes an instrument of war, revealing how technique can look like a skilled artistic choice and also like disciplined endurance commanded by war.

A detailed description of movement elements like :

- spins (chakkars)
- Props
- Music (Taal)
- percussive footwork (Tatkar)
- Rhythmic syllables (Bol)
- Tempo (Laya)

MY ARGUMENT

I argue that Xenos stages a tension between **his lineage** and **war as a system that organizes bodies:** Akram Khan uses Kathak-derived movement in a very deliberate way to depict pain and psychological strain across the soldier's journey. Through taal (rhythmic cycle), the relationship between music and silence, percussive footwork, and shifts in tempo, the choreography moves through different physical and mental states like control, alertness, panic, fatigue, and breakdown. The contemporary movement language alongside Kathak also matters as it registers the colonial frame of the story, shaping the soldier's experience as something pressured by an external system, where the body is both expressive and controlled.

"XENOS" IS DERIVED FROM THE ANCIENT GREEK WORD FOR "STRANGER," "GUEST," OR "ALIEN".

THE CHARACTER IN XENOS IS ESSENTIALLY A COLONIAL SOLDIER FIGHTING IN A WAR THAT ISN'T "HIS," IN A LAND WHERE HE IS TREATED AS AN OUTSIDER

WHY IT MATTERS?

I had the honor of seeing Akram Khan perform live in 2023 in India, marking his final performances as a dancer in a full-length piece. I also attended a post-Xenos discussion where I heard him speak about the work directly. This matters to me because Khan was a major influence on my dance upbringing as he’s widely respected across Indian dance communities. What stayed with me from hearing him speak was how much research and care went into building Xenos from histories that are often flattened or told without the body. This War is heavily studied in India, but experiencing it through dance gave me another way of understanding it and experiencing the human cost carried in movement. This project is important to me because Akram Khan shaped the way I understood what a classical Indian dance–trained body can do on global stages.